

In early 1992 the famous “Dedicated” virus appeared, based on the first known polymorphic generator, the MtE and the first in a series of MtE-based viruses. The polymorphic generator was essentially an object module (OBJ) file; to get a polymorphic mutant virus from a conventional non-encrypting virus one only needed to link object modules together—the polymorphic OBJ file and the virus OBJ file. The era of “script-kiddies” had dawned and with it an industry of do-it-yourself, 30-minute-viruses. Soon books promising to teach you how to write viruses in weeks made their appearance.

The Michelangelo virus was the first media darling. Much like the Y2K anti-climax, Michelangelo was heralded by much doom and gloom alerts, with predictions of massive, worldwide damages. In actuality, very little happened! The same year the Dark Avenger Mutation Engine (DAME) became the first toolkit that could be used to turn any virus polymorphic. By 1993, polymorphic viruses were populous in virus land. Some celebrities from that era: Bootache, CivilWar, Crusher, Dudley, Fly, Freddy, Ginger, Grog, Haifa, Moctezuma, MVF, Necros, Nukehard, PcFly, Predator, Satanbug, Sandra, Shoker, Todor, Tremor, Trigger and Uruguay.

These viruses required special methods of detection, including emulation of the virus’s executable code and mathematical algorithms for restoring parts of the code and data in virus. Polymorphic generators were also proliferating alongside their progeny. Several new ones appeared utilizing complex methods of generating polymorphic code. By the end of 1993 there were four known generators of polymorphic code: MTE 0.90 (Mutation Engine), four versions of TPE (Trident Polymorphic Engine), NED (Nuke Encryption Device) and DAME (Dark Angel’s Multiple Encryptor).

Generation Next

As viruses got more prominent, the means to create them kept getting easier and sometime in the middle of 1992 appeared the first do-it-yourself virus kit. July 5, 1992: the first viral code con-